Forum:	Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee (GA3)
Issue:	Addressing the cultural assimilation of marginalised refugee communities.
Author:	Katerina Pouli
Position:	Deputy President

Personal Introduction

Dear Delegates,

My name is Katerina Pouli, and I am an 11th-grade student at Geitonas School. It is my utmost honour to serve as a Co-Chair in this year's Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee, and I look forward to working with each one of you in drafting resolutions and engaging in fruitful debate! I started my MUN journey two years ago, and since then, I have been provided with countless opportunities to develop my public speaking, collaborative, and critical thinking skills, while also deepening my curiosity and understanding of the world's global issues.

In this study guide, you will be exploring the issue of "Addressing the cultural assimilation of marginalised refugee communities". The purpose of this guide is to provide you with a foundation for your research and help you have a clear understanding of the issue at hand. I highly encourage you to conduct your own research on the topic and on your allocated country's stance.

I look forward to meeting you all in October!

Best,

Katerina Pouli

Introduction

The cultural assimilation of marginalised refugee communities refers to the process by which refugees adapt to the language, values, customs, and social norms of their host society.[1] While assimilation can help refugees access education, employment, and social opportunities, it is often a complex and controversial issue. Many refugee groups face pressure to abandon aspects of their cultural identity in order to fit into the society of their host country. This may include changing the way they dress, speak, practice their religion, or celebrate cultural traditions. When refugees are expected to assimilate rather than maintain their own culture, they may experience exclusion, discrimination, and a loss of connection to their heritage.[2] Over time, this can weaken cultural

[1]Soken-Huberty, E. (2022, May 22). *What is cultural assimilation?* Human Rights Careers. https://www.humanrightscareers.com/issues/what-is-cultural-assimilation/

[2]Story, W. T., Afifi, R. A., Clayden, A., Liese, K. L., Mirza, M., & Jeremiah, R. D. (2025). A case for achieving Refugee Health Equity: Dismantling the influence of structural oppression in refugee

traditions, reduce a sense of belonging, and negatively affect both individual well-being and community identity.

Addressing cultural assimilation involves finding a balance between social integration and preservation of cultural heritage and identity. Host communities and community organisations play important roles in creating inclusive environments where refugees can participate fully in society without being forced to give up their cultural traditions, as they have a direct influence on how refugees are treated. Host communities also shape the social environment that refugees experience after arriving in a new country. While governments may provide legal protection and basic services, it is local communities that determine whether refugees feel accepted, respected, and able to participate in everyday life. When communities welcome refugees, they create opportunities for education, employment, social interaction, and cultural exchange, helping refugees build confidence and a sense of belonging.[3] Community organisations also provide essential support, such as language classes, settlement services, counselling and advocacy, all of which help refugees overcome barriers to integration. At the same time, they encourage multiculturalism by promoting respect for different cultures, allowing refugees to preserve their language, traditions, and beliefs, rather than feeling pressured to abandon them.[4]

Key Terms and Definitions

Refugee

"Refugees are people who have been forced to flee their homes to escape war, violence, conflict or persecution. A refugee crosses an international border to find safety in another country and is unable to return home for fear of persecution on the grounds of race, religion, nationality, political opinion, or membership in a particular social group[5]." There are many types of refugees, such as asylum seekers, who are people who have fled their homes and have requested international protection in another country, Internally Displaced People (IDPs), who are forced to flee their homes but have not

health disparities. *Health Education & Behavior*, *52*(5), 489–493. https://doi.org/10.1177/10901981251363160

[3] ICMC Comms. (2025, November 26). *The role of local communities in Refugee Integration - the International Catholic Migration Commission (ICMC)*. The International Catholic Migration Commission (ICMC). https://www.icmc.net/2025/11/26/role-of-local-communities-in-refugee-integration/

[4] Lito Nantsou, Karanikola, Z., & Nektaria Palaiologou. (2025). Building resilience: The critical role of multicultural education to cope with the psychological trauma of migrant and refugee youth. *Behavioral Sciences*, *15*(7), 916–916. https://doi.org/10.3390/bs15070916

[5] *What is a refugee? Understanding the definition*. (2026, May 14). UNHCR - Aotearoa NZ; Aotearoa New Zealand for UNHCR. https://www.unrefugees.org.nz/our-stories/what-is-a-refugee-understanding-the-definition/

crossed a border, and war refugees, who are people forced to leave their country to escape and protect themselves from war and its implications.[6]

Discrimination

The treatment of a "person or particular group of people differently, especially in a worse way than the way in which you treat other people, because of their race, gender, sexuality, or religion[7]." Discrimination is very commonly faced by refugees in employment, healthcare, education, and housing, as well as legal protection.

Cultural Assimilation

"Cultural assimilation is a process through which individuals or groups adopt the cultural norms, values, and behaviours of another community. It encompasses changes in language, attire, mannerisms, and sometimes, the relinquishment of one's original cultural identity to blend into the host society."[8] There are two types of cultural assimilation:

Voluntary Assimilation

"Voluntary assimilation occurs when migrants willingly adopt aspects of the host culture, finding a balance that suits their personal and communal identities"[9]

Forced Assimilation

"Forced assimilation is an imposition by the host society, often underpinned by systemic or overt pressures."[10]

Multiculturalism

"Multiculturalism is the view that cultures, races, and ethnicities, particularly those of minority groups, deserve acknowledgment of their differences within a dominant political culture. This acknowledgement can take many forms, from recognizing cultural contributions to demands for special protection under the law, or autonomous governance rights."[11]

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[6] SGI (2022). *The different types of refugees*. [online] SGI. Available at: https://sgi.ngo/the-different-types-of-refugees/

[7] Cambridge Dictionary. (2025). *Discrimination | meaning in the cambridge English dictionary*. Cambridge.Org. https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/discrimination

[8] ICMC Comms. (2025, November 26). *Cultural assimilation vs. cultural preservation: The migrant dilemma - the International Catholic Migration Commission (ICMC)*. The International Catholic Migration Commission (ICMC). https://www.icmc.net/2025/11/26/cultural-assimilation-vs-cultural-preservation

[9] Ibid.

[10] Ibid.

[11] Eagan, J. L. (2024). Multiculturalism | sociology. In *Encyclopædia Britannica*. https://www.britannica.com/topic/multiculturalism

Acculturation

"Acculturation refers to the psychological, social, and cultural transformation that takes place through direct contact between two cultures, wherein one or both engage in adapting to dominant cultural influences without compromising their essential distinctiveness."[12]

Berry's Model of Acculturation

Berry's Model of Acculturation, developed by psychologist John W. Berry, categorises how individuals adapt to a new culture. It is based on two core dimensions: the desire to maintain one's heritage culture and the desire to interact with the host society. The intersection of the two dimensions yields four distinct acculturation strategies:

Integration: Individuals maintain their original cultural identity while simultaneously adopting aspects of the host culture. This is generally considered the most psychologically adaptive strategy.

Assimilation: Individuals abandon their heritage culture and fully adopt the norms and values of the dominant host culture.

Separation: Individuals reject the host culture and focus exclusively on preserving their culture of origin.

Marginalization: Individuals reject both their original culture and the host culture, often leading to alienation and a loss of cultural identity.[13]

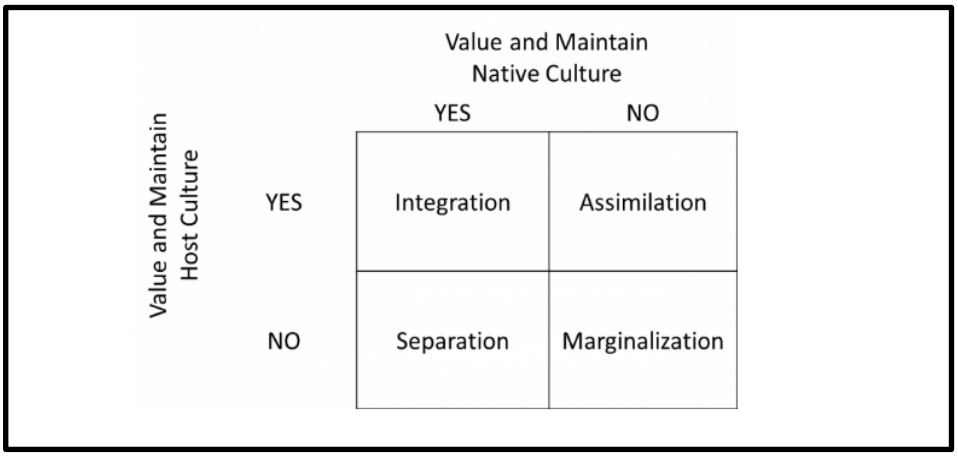


Fig 1: "Berry's Acculturation Model"[14]

[12]Wikipedia Contributors. (2019, March 24). *Acculturation*. Wikipedia; Wikimedia Foundation. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Acculturation

[13] Worthy, L. D., Lavigne, T., & Romero, F. (2020, July 27). *Berry's model of acculturation*. Open.Maricopa.Edu; MMOER. https://open.maricopa.edu/culturepsychology/chapter/berrys-model-of-acculturation/

[14] Ibid.

Host Community

"Host community refers to the country of asylum and the local, regional, and national governmental, social, and economic structures within which refugees live."[15]

Melting Pot Theory

The Melting Pot Theory is a sociological metaphor describing how a heterogeneous society becomes more homogenous.[16]

Background Information

Historical Background

The history of refugees is not only a history of persecution and displacement, but also one of adaptation, integration, and assimilation into new societies. Throughout it, people forced to flee their homelands have rebuilt their lives by contributing their skills, knowledge, and cultural traditions to their host countries. Case studies reveal that integration has often been a gradual process shaped by legal status, economic participation, social attitudes, and cultural adaptation.

16th Century

In 16th-century France, where thousands of French Protestants were systematically oppressed by the Catholic French Crown, the term réfugiés—meaning "to run away"- arose. Beginning in the 1520s and accelerating dramatically after the St. Bartholomew's Day Massacre of 1572, when over 10,000 French Protestants,[17] namely the Huguenots, were assassinated in a single day, approximately 200,000 Huguenots fled France.[18] About one-fifth of these refugees went to England, while the rest went to the Netherlands, Germany, Scandinavia, and even the Americas.[19] The Huguenot experience in England demonstrates one of the first cases of religious refugee assimilation. In England, Protestant refugees from the French Wars were largely welcomed, especially in areas where they brought new skills. The Huguenots became silk weavers and revolutionized England's textile industries, while they also transformed the arts and journalism, as many were silversmiths, engravers, and jewellers, and generally brought French tastes and technical expertise that influenced English craftsmanship.

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[15] *UNHCR-NGO toolkit for practical cooperation on resettlement. Community outreach - outreach to host communities: Definitions and FAQs*. (n.d.). Unhcr. Retrieved October 15, 2026, from https://www.unhcr.org/publications/unhcr-ngo-toolkit-practical-cooperation-resettlement-community-outreach-outreach-0

[16] European Center for Populism Studies. (2000). *Melting pot - ECPS*. European Center for Populism Studies. https://www.populismstudies.org/Vocabulary/melting-pot

[17] Michon, H. (2018, August 21). *St. Bartholomew's day massacre: Causes, events, impact*. ThoughtCo. https://www.thoughtco.com/saint-bartholomews-day-massacre-4173411

[18] *Huguenot society :: Huguenot history*. (2026). Huguenotsociety.Org.Uk. http://www.huguenotsociety.org.uk/history.html

[19] Ibid.

Because of this, they managed to provide much of the hard cash for the financial revolution that took place in London in the 1690s.[20] Despite this initial distinctiveness, the Huguenots were gradually absorbed by the English people, and within three generations, they had adopted English as their first language, demonstrating that cultural assimilation occurred naturally over time without forced policies.

17th century

One of the most significant refugee movements of the seventeenth century was the Great Serb Migration of 1690.[21] During the Great Turkish War (1683–1699), many Orthodox Serbs supported the Habsburg Monarchy in its campaign against the Ottoman Empire. However, when the Ottoman forces regained control of parts of the Balkans, thousands of Serbs feared retaliation due to their collaboration with the Habsburgs. Many families, led by the Patriarch at the time, fled north across the Danube and Sava rivers into Habsburg territory.[22] Recognizing both the humanitarian and strategic importance of the refugees, Emperor Leopold I granted them a series of privileges, including religious freedom, the right to elect their own church leaders, and limited self-government. These rights facilitated their integration into Habsburg society while allowing them to preserve their Orthodox faith, language, and tradition. Unlike cases of rapid cultural assimilation, the Serbs largely maintained a distinct ethnic and religious identity for generations. Nevertheless, they became economically and politically integrated into Habsburg society through military service, trade, and local administration. The Great Serb Migration illustrates that refugees can become productive members of a host society while preserving their cultural heritage, and as such, that successful refugee integration does not necessarily require complete cultural assimilation.

18th century

During the eighteenth century, a significant refugee movement was the Acadian Expulsion of 1755–1764.[23] The Acadians were French-speaking settlers who had lived for generations in Acadia, present-day Nova Scotia, New Brunswick, and Prince Edward Island, in Canada. Following the outbreak of the French and Indian War, British authorities viewed the Acadians as a potential security threat

[20] *Our migration story: The making of Britain*. (n.d.). Www.Ourmigrationstory.Org.Uk. Retrieved 15 October 2026, from https://www.ourmigrationstory.org.uk/oms/thomas-papillons-advertisement

[21] Research, S. S., & Maroš Melichárek. (n.d.-b). *Maroš Melichárek, 'great migration of the serbs (1690) and its reflections in modern historiography', Serbian Studies Research, vol. 8, no. 1, 2017, 87-102.* Academia.Edu. Retrieved 15 October 2026, from https://www.academia.edu/35488747

[22] Točanac Radović, I. (2022). The great migration of serbs and the question of the Serbian ethnic and religious community in the Habsburg Monarchy. *Migrations in the Slavic Cultural Space. From the Middle Ages to the Present Day*, 15–27. https://doi.org/10.18778/8331-033-6.02

[23] Vasquez-Parra, A. (2024). *The acadian deportation, women, and refugee resettlement in the British and French Atlantic (1755-1793) - commonplace*. Commonplace. https://commonplace.online/article/the-acadian-deportation-women-and-refugee-resettlement/

because they refused to swear an unconditional oath of allegiance to the British Crown while maintaining their Catholic faith and cultural ties to France. In 1755, the British government ordered the forced deportation of approximately 11,000 Acadians.[24] Families were deliberately separated, their homes and farms were destroyed, leading to their dispersion across the Thirteen Colonies, France, Britain, and the Caribbean. Thousands died during the deportation from disease, starvation, and shipwreck.[25] Unlike voluntary refugee movements, the Acadian Expulsion illustrates how forced displacement was used as a means of weakening a community's identity and encouraging assimilation into an English-speaking society. However, the outcomes varied considerably. While many Acadians gradually assimilated into the societies where they were resettled, others eventually found refuge in Spanish-controlled Louisiana, where they re-established their communities. There, they preserved many aspects of their French language, Catholic religion, and cultural traditions despite adapting to a new social and political environment. The Acadian experience demonstrates that forced assimilation policies do not always succeed in eliminating cultural identity. Instead, it highlights the complicated relationship between displacement, integration, and assimilation, showing that refugee communities may adapt economically and socially while continuing to preserve a distinct cultural heritage across generations.

19th century

The conclusion of the Caucasian War in 1864 triggered one of the largest forced population displacements of the 19th century.[26] The Circassians were indigenous Muslim people of the North Caucasus who had resisted Russian imperial expansion for decades during the Caucasian War (1817-1864). Following Russia's military victory, the imperial government adopted a policy of mass expulsion to remove the Circassian population from strategically important territories and secure permanent control of the region by destroying villages, confiscating land, and forcing hundreds of thousands of Circassians to go to Black Sea ports, where they would be transported to the Ottoman Empire. The journey was catastrophic, as overcrowded ships, disease, starvation, and exposure claimed countless lives. An estimated 800,000 to 1.5 million Circassians were displaced,[27] while many more died during the campaign and deportation, which led many scholars to describe the event as a

[24] *Expulsion of the acadians | history | research starters | EBSCOhost*. (2023). Ebsco. https://www.ebsco.com/research-starters/history/expulsion-acadians/

[25] Peralty, D. (2026, August). *Great expulsion acadians 1755: 2026 Complete guide*. Acadian Genealogy - Historical Acadian-Cajun Resources. https://www.acadian.org/great-expulsion-acadians-1755-2026-complete-guide/

[26] Guide Georgia, T., & Private Transfers, B. L. T. (2026, July 8). *The caucasian war (1817–1864) and Georgia*. Travel Guide Georgia | Book Local Tours & Private Transfers. https://travelguide.ge/en/articles/kavkasiis-omi-1817/

[27] Borgen Project. (2017, November 14). *10 Facts about the circassian genocide – the borgen project*. Borgenproject.Org. https://borgenproject.org/10-facts-about-the-circassian-genocide/

genocide. Survivors were resettled throughout the Ottoman Empire, particularly in present-day Turkey, Jordan, Syria, and parts of the Balkans, where they were often used to populate frontier regions and strengthen imperial control.[28] The long-term outcomes of the exodus varied across host societies. In many areas, Circassians gradually integrated into local economies and military institutions, with some communities eventually assimilating linguistically and culturally into Turkish or Arabic society through intermarriage and urbanisation. However, many others preserved their language, customs, and communal identity by establishing separate villages and cultural institutions. The Circassian Genocide and Exodus shows how forced displacement can permanently reshape both refugee populations and host societies. It also demonstrates that although refugees may successfully integrate into new environments, assimilation is neither inevitable nor uniform, as many Circassian communities have retained a distinct cultural identity that endures to the present day. What enabled them to maintain their cultural identity, unlike other populations, were many factors, such as their being settled in concentrated communities, their arrival in large numbers, and their identity being much more than just a language.[29]

20th century

The partition of India in 1947 marked one of the largest and most traumatic forced migrations in modern history.[30] Following the end of British colonial rule, British India was divided into the independent states of India and Pakistan based largely on religious demographics. The partition was intended to resolve growing tensions between Hindus and Muslims, but instead triggered widespread communal violence, political instability, and mass displacement. As new borders were drawn, an estimated 14–18 million people were forced to leave their homes, with Hindus and Sikhs migrating to India and Muslims moving to Pakistan.[31] The migration was accompanied by horrific violence, including massacres, sexual violence, abductions, and the destruction of entire villages, resulting in the deaths of an estimated one to two million people.[32] Despite the scale of the humanitarian crisis, many refugees gradually rebuilt their lives in their new countries. Governments

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[28] in. (2022). *Exile of circassians tragic event in human history*. Aa.Com.Tr. https://www.aa.com.tr/en/world/exile-of-circassians-tragic-event-in-human-history/2594371

[29]davidb. (2013, May 26). *Circassian pride and pain - icej*. ICEJ. https://www.icej.org/blog/circassian-pride-and-pain/
/.

[30] Sakinah Khuram. (2026b). The partition of India across generations: Memory, forgetting, and diasporic identity. *Critical Debates in Humanities, Science and Global Justice*. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2023.1201681;citation_firstpage=1201681;citation_publication_date=2023;citation_author

[31] Satia, P. (2019, March 8). *Stanford scholar explains the history of India's partition, its ongoing effects today*. News.Stanford.Edu. https://news.stanford.edu/stories/2019/03/partition-1947-continues-haunt-india-pakistan-stanford-scholar-says

[32] Brocklehurst, Steven. 'Partition of India: "They Would Have Slaughtered Us"'. *BBC News*, 11 Aug. 2017, https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-scotland-40874496.

established refugee camps and implemented resettlement programs, while refugees contributed to economic development through trade, agriculture, industry, and entrepreneurship. Over time, many displaced families integrated into their host societies by participating in local economies, education, and political life. However, assimilation was often complex, as many refugees retained strong memories of their former homes, cultural traditions, and regional identities that were passed down through subsequent generations. The partition of India illustrates that successful integration does not necessarily require the loss of cultural identity, as many refugee communities became fully incorporated into Indian and Pakistani society while continuing to preserve their distinct historical and cultural heritage.

Current challenges to refugee integration

Despite the important contributions that refugees can make to their host societies, successful integration remains one of the greatest challenges facing the international community today. Refugees frequently arrive after experiencing conflict, persecution, or displacement, often carrying the physical and psychological effects of trauma while attempting to rebuild their lives in unfamiliar environments. One of the most immediate barriers to integration is access to stable housing, as many host countries struggle to provide adequate accommodation for large numbers of arrivals due to their lack of facilities. Limited employment opportunities, the non-recognition of foreign qualifications, and language barriers often prevent refugees from achieving economic self-sufficiency, increasing their dependence on public assistance. Access to education and healthcare also remains uneven, particularly in less economically developed countries that host the majority of the world's refugee population. At the same time, social integration can be hindered by discrimination, xenophobia, and misinformation, which may contribute to social exclusion and reduce opportunities for meaningful interaction with local communities. Refugees may also face legal obstacles, including asylum procedures, restrictions on employment, and uncertainty regarding their long-term legal status. These challenges constantly delay integration and negatively affect mental health, social mobility, and community participation. Nevertheless, research has consistently shown that when refugees are provided with access to education, employment, legal protection, and language training, they are more likely to integrate successfully and make lasting economic and social contributions to their host societies [33]

[33] Chia, J. (2019, February 1). *Economic, civic and social contributions of refugees and humanitarian entrants: A literature review*. Https://Www.Refugeecouncil.Org.Au/. https://www.refugeecouncil.org.au/economic-literature-review/

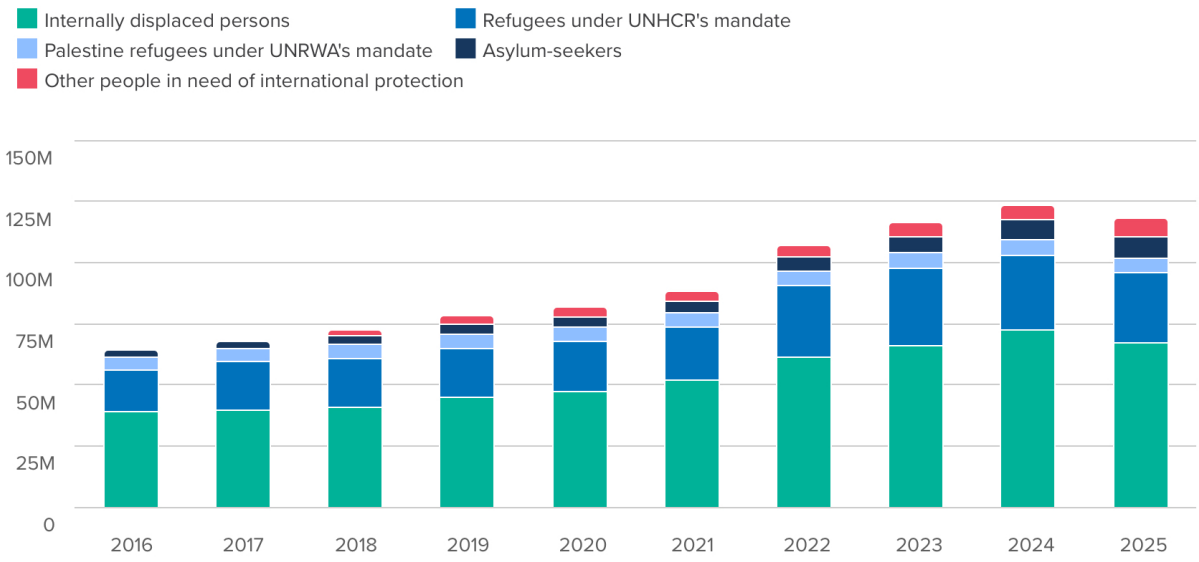


Fig 2: People forcibly displaced worldwide | 2016 - 2025[34]

Benefits of successful refugee integration

Successful refugee integration can generate significant benefits for both refugees and their host societies. When refugees are provided with access to education, employment, healthcare, and legal protection, they are better able to become self-sufficient and actively contribute to their new communities. Economically, refugees can help address labour shortages, establish businesses, and stimulate innovation through the skills, knowledge, and experience they bring. Their participation in the workforce also increases tax revenues and supports long-term economic growth, particularly in countries facing ageing populations or declining birth rates[35]. Beyond economic contributions, successful integration promotes social cohesion by encouraging interaction and mutual understanding between marginalised refugee communities and host countries. Refugees often enrich their new societies through language, cuisine, traditions, art, and entrepreneurship, contributing to greater cultural diversity. At the same time, inclusive integration policies can reduce social tensions, discrimination, and marginalisation by fostering equal opportunities and civic participation. Historical and modern examples demonstrate that refugees are not merely recipients of assistance

[34] United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. (2024, April 6). Global trends. *Unhcr*. https://www.unhcr.org/global-trends

[35] Pesch, R. (2023, August 10). *Hiring refugees is good for the world — And for business. Here's why*. World Economic Forum. https://www.weforum.org/stories/jobs-and-the-future-of-work/hiring-refugees-good-business-world/

but can become valuable contributors to the economic, social, and cultural development of their host countries.

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Events
24 August, 1572	St. Bartholomew's Day Massacre: Thousands of Huguenots are killed in France, triggering a large-scale refugee movement across Europe.[36]
18 October, 1685	Revocation of the Edict of Nantes. Louis XIV outlaw Protestantism in France, promoting the largest Huguenot exodus and demonstrating successful long-term assimilation in several host countries.[37]
1690	Great Serb Migration: Tens of thousands of Serbs fled to Ottoman territory to the Habsburg Empire, where they integrat while preserving their cultural identity.[38]
1755-1764	Acadian Expulsion: British authorities forcibly deport Acadians, illustrating an early attempt at forced assimilation.[39]

[36]Michon, H. (2018, August 21). *St. Bartholomew's day massacre: Causes, events, impact*. ThoughtCo. https://www.thoughtco.com/saint-bartholomews-day-massacre-4173411

[37] van der Linden, D. (2022). The revocation of the edict of Nantes. *The Revocation of the Edict of Nantes*. https://doi.org/10.4324/9780367347093-rerw31-1

[38] Brzozowska, Zofia, et al. *Migrations in the Slavic Cultural Space: From the Middle Ages to the Present Day*. Archeobooks, 2022, https://repozytorium.uni.lodz.pl/handle/11089/55936.

[39]Marsh, J. H. (2013, September 4). *Acadian expulsion (the great upheaval)*. Thecanadianencyclopedia.Ca; The Canadian Encyclopedia. https://thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/the-deportation-of-the-acadians-feature

1864	Circassian Genocide and Exodus: Mass expulsion of the Circassians by the Russian Empire lead to one of the nineteenth century's largest refugee crises.[40]
14-15 August,1947	Partition of India: Millions of people are displaced during the creation of Pakistan, making it one of history's largest forced migrations.[41]
28 July, 1951	Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees: Establishes the legal definition of a refugee and recognises rights supporting long-term integration.[42]
4 October, 1967	Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees: Expands the 1951 Convention by removing its geographic and temporal limitations.[43]
4 April, 1979	Canada launches the Private Sponsorship of Refugees Program: Introduces a community-based model of refugee integration that is being adopted internationally.[44]
17 December, 2018	Global Compact on Refugees: Encourages international cooperation and emphasizes on education, employment, and social inclusion as key elements of successful refugee integration.[45]

[40] Fahmidan Team. (2026, June 16). *The circassian genocide and the destruction of the circassian people*. Fahmidan Journal. https://www.fahmidan.net/post/the-circassian-genocide-and-the-destruction-of-the-circassian-people

[41] Kulik, R. M. (2023, November 28). *Partition of India | Summary, Cause, Effects, & Significance | Britannica*. Www.Britannica.Com; Britannica. https://www.britannica.com/event/Partition-of-India

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[42] UNHCR. (n.d.). *The 1951 refugee convention*. Unhcr. Retrieved October 15, 2026, from https://www.unhcr.org/about-unhcr/overview/1951-refugee-convention

[43] *Protocol relating to the status of refugees*. (n.d.). Legal.Un.Org. Retrieved October 15, 2026, from https://legal.un.org/avl/ha/prsr/prsr.html

[44] *PSR program - AURA*. (2025, June 20). AURA. https://auraforrefugees.org/about-aura/private-sponsorship-of-refugees-program/

[45] *The global compact on refugees*. (n.d.). The Global Compact on Refugees | UNHCR. Retrieved October 15, 2026, from https://globalcompactrefugees.org/about-digital-platform/global-compact-refugees

Major Actors Involved

Sweden

Sweden has adopted a comprehensive approach to refugee integration that seeks to promote participation in Swedish society while respecting cultural diversity. The Swedish government places significant emphasis on language education, as knowledge of Swedish is considered essential for refugees to access education, employment, healthcare, and other public services. Refugees and other newly arrived immigrants can receive support in learning Swedish through publicly funded language programmes designed to facilitate their participation in society.[46] Furthermore, employment is another central component of Sweden's integration strategy, with government agencies assisting with job searches, vocational training, skills assessments, and connections with employers.[47] This approach aims to reduce economic marginalisation, as underemployment and economic dependency can contribute to the social isolation of refugee communities. Sweden also provides refugees with access to essential public services, including healthcare and education, under the broader principle of equal access to welfare institutions.[48] Housing assistance and municipal integration programmes further seek to help refugees establish stable lives within Swedish communities. At the same time, Sweden recognises that integration should not require refugees to completely abandon their cultural, linguistic, or religious identities. The country has historically supported multicultural initiatives and has provided opportunities, such as support for cultural associations, community organisations, and activities, for minority communities to maintain aspects of their cultural heritage. The Swedish government generally distinguishes between integration and assimilation, but its approach has also faced challenges. Those include residential segregation, differences in employment outcomes, and difficulties faced by some refugee communities in achieving long-term socioeconomic inclusion. These challenges demonstrate that providing equal legal access to public services does not automatically guarantee equal social inclusion.

Canada

Canada has developed a multicultural approach to refugee integration that seeks to enable newcomers to participate fully in Canadian society while preserving their cultural, linguistic, and religious identities. The Canadian government provides refugees with settlement services, including language training, employment assistance, education, and support in accessing housing and public

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[46] *Syllabus for municipal adult education in Swedish tuition for immigrants (SFI)*. (n.d.). Retrieved October 15, 2026, from https://www.skolverket.se/download/18.4fc05a3f164131a7418ce9/1535097772538/Kursplan%20sfi%20engelska.pdf

[47] *Introduction programme*. (2025). Arbetsförmedlingen. https://arbetsformedlingen.se/other-languages/english-engelska/additional-support/support-a-z/introduction-programme

[48] *Ny i Stockholm*. (2026). Nyistockholm.Se. https://nyistockholm.se/engelska/welcome-to-sweden/new-in-sweden/

services. Language education plays an important role in integration, as proficiency in English or French can improve refugees' access to employment, education, and social institutions.[49] However, Canada generally does not view learning one of its official languages as requiring refugees to abandon their mother tongue or cultural traditions. This reflects Canada's broader policy of multiculturalism, which recognises cultural diversity as a characteristic of Canadian society rather than an obstacle to national unity. Refugees are therefore encouraged to participate in Canadian political, economic, and social life while continuing to practise their cultural and religious traditions. Canada has also supported programmes that help refugees maintain connections with their cultural heritage while developing relationships with their host population.[50] This approach demonstrates that integration does not necessarily require cultural homogenisation. At the same time, the Canadian government faces challenges, including discrimination, socioeconomic inequality, employment barriers, and the possibility of social isolation in highly concentrated communities. These challenges show that multicultural policies alone cannot guarantee equal participation or prevent marginalised refugee communities from becoming socially or economically excluded. Canada, therefore, has placed importance on anti-discrimination measures and equal access to education, employment, healthcare, and other public services.

United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)

The United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) is one of the most important international actors involved in protecting refugees and addressing the challenges associated with displacement. Established in 1950, the organisation is mandated to protect refugees, asylum seekers, stateless people, and other forcibly displaced populations around the world.[51] The UNHCR works with governments to ensure that refugees have access to fundamental rights, including protection from discrimination, violence, and forced return to situations where they may face persecution. Its primary focus is refugee protection rather than cultural preservation, but it recognises that cultural identity can be an important component of a refugee's dignity, wellbeing, and social inclusion. The organisation therefore supports approaches to integration that allow refugees to participate in their host societies without being forced to abandon their cultural, linguistic, or religious identities. It also promotes access to education, healthcare, employment, housing, and legal protection, all of which can reduce the social and economic marginalisation that may contribute to cultural isolation. A particularly important principle for the UNHCR is non-discrimination, meaning that refugees should be able to access essential services regardless of their background. The organisation works closely

[49] Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada. (2024). *ARCHIVED – language assessment and training services - Canada.Ca*. Canada.Ca. https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/corporate/partners-service-providers/funding/settlement-funding-2024/language-services.html

[50] *Language and cultural orientation programs: Bridging gaps for refugee and displaced persons' integration*. (2018). RefPIC. https://www.refugeecanada.org/education-and-skill-development/language-and-cultural-orientation-programs

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[51] UNHCR. (2024). *ABOUT UNHCR*. Unhcr. https://www.unhcr.org/about-unhcr

with national governments, local authorities, and NGOs to develop programmes that respond to the specific needs of displaced communities. Refugee participation is particularly important because policies designed without consultation with affected communities can unintentionally undermine cultural practices or exclude minority groups. The UNHCR can therefore encourage governments to involve refugees in the design and implementation of integration policies, and it heavily relies on cooperation from them to implement its programmes.[52]

International Organisation for Migration (IOM)

The International Organisation for Migration (IOM) plays a significant role in addressing the cultural assimilation and social exclusion of marginalised refugee communities worldwide. IOM promotes integration rather than forced assimilation, supporting refugees in adapting to their host societies while preserving their cultural identity, traditions, and languages. It provides cultural orientation, language training, employment support, and information on rights and responsibilities to help refugees become self-reliant.[53] IOM also works with host communities, local authorities, teachers, and service providers to improve cultural awareness and reduce discrimination and xenophobia. Through social-mixing initiatives, IOM encourages meaningful interaction between refugees and host communities to build trust, empathy, and social cohesion. The organisation emphasises that integration should be a two-way process requiring adaptation and participation from both refugees and receiving communities. The IOM therefore supports programs that allow refugees to participate actively in education, employment, community life, and decision-making. For example, IOM's HELIOS program in Greece has provided language and professional skills courses while promoting awareness within host communities.[54] IOM further advocates for inclusive policies that recognise refugees' cultural diversity as a potential contribution to their host societies.

UN Documents and International Agreements

The 1951 Refugee Convention

The 1951 Refugee Convention (officially known as the Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees) is the cornerstone international treaty defining who a refugee is and outlining their rights and the legal obligations of states toward them. It was adopted on July 28th of 1951 in Geneva; however, it entered into force on April 22nd of 1954.[55] Initially, it applied only to people displaced by events

[52] UNHCR. (2023). *What we do*. Unhcr. https://www.unhcr.org/what-we-do

[53]International Organization for Migration. (2024). *Who we are*. International Organization for Migration. https://www.iom.int/who-we-are

[54] *Helios+ | iom Greece*. (2019). Iom.Int. https://greece.iom.int/helios

[55] 'The 1951 Refugee Convention and 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees | UNHCR'. *Unhcr*, 1967, https://www.unhcr.org/media/1951-refugee-convention-and-1967-protocol-relating-status-refugees.

occurring before the 1st of January 1951, mainly in Europe after World War II; however, the 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees removed these time and geographic limitations, making the convention applicable worldwide.[56] The Convention is important because it is the main international agreement that protects people who have been forced to flee their countries due to persecution. It defines who qualifies as a refugee, protects refugees from being sent back to countries where they face danger (the principle of non-refoulement), guarantees basic rights, and sets common standards that countries should follow when dealing with refugees. The Convention has helped refugees around the world, including those from the Hungarian Revolution of 1956, the Vietnam War, conflicts in Afghanistan and the civil war in Syria.[57] The 1951 Refugee Convention is still in effect, as it remains the foundation of international refugee law and one of the most important human rights treaties in the world. Although it does not address every modern form of displacement, such as climate change or environmental disasters, it is still legally binding for its member states and continues to protect millions of refugees.[58]

The 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees

The 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees is an international treaty that expanded the protection provided by the Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees. The 1967 Protocol made the 1951 Convention applicable to refugees everywhere in the world and not just people displaced by events before a certain date.[59] It removed the Convention's time limit and its geographical restrictions, and it allowed people fleeing persecution anywhere in the world to receive protection under international law. The Protocol has provided legal protection for refugees from many major crises, including the Rwandan Genocide in 1994, the persecution of the Rohingya from Myanmar, and the war in Ukraine.[60] The Protocol is still in effect and remains an essential part of international refugee law, as it transformed refugee protection from a post-WWII agreement into a global system.

The Common European Asylum System (CEAS)[61]

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[56] The 1951 Convention and 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees (2011). https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2025-02/1951-refugee-convention-1967-protocol.pdf

[57] UNHCR. (n.d.). *The 1951 refugee convention*. Unhcr. Retrieved 17 October 2026, from https://www.unhcr.org/about-unhcr/overview/1951-refugee-convention

[58] 'The 1951 Refugee Convention and 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees | UNHCR'. *Unhcr*, 1967, https://www.unhcr.org/media/1951-refugee-convention-and-1967-protocol-relating-status-refugees.

[59] United Nations. (1966, December 16). *Protocol relating to the status of refugees*. Ohchr. https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/protocol-relating-status-refugees

[60] *An introduction to international protection protecting persons of concern to UNHCR self-study module 1*. (2005). https://www.onlinelibrary.iihl.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/05/2005-UNHCR-An-Introduction-to-International-Protection-1.pdf

[61] EUAA. '2.1 The Common European Asylum System and Current Issues'. *European Union Agency for Asylum*, 2020, https://www.euaa.europa.eu/asylum-report-2020/21-common-european-asylum-system-and-current-issues.

The Common European Asylum System is the European Union's framework for ensuring that people seeking asylum are treated according to common standards across EU countries.[62] The CEAS was first initiated in 1999, and then gradually built through EU legislation. It aims to create a fair and consistent asylum process by establishing common rules for how EU countries process asylum applications, ensuring that asylum seekers receive basic standards of treatment, helping determine which EU country is responsible for examining an asylum application and promoting cooperation among EU member states to manage migration and refugee protection. The CEAS has helped across the European Union, particularly during major refugee movements such as the 2015-2016 European refugee crisis and the displacement caused by the war in Ukraine. The CEAS remains in effect, but has undergone significant reforms. Specifically, in 2024, the European Union adopted the EU Pact on Migration and Asylum, which updated and strengthened many parts of the original treaty. The Common European Asylum System remains the foundation of asylum policy in the European Union.[63] Although it has faced criticism for unequal responsibility among Member States and inconsistent implementation, its purpose continues to be ensuring that people seeking international protection receive fair treatment while helping EU countries manage asylum in a coordinated way.

The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration

The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration (GCM) is the first global agreement that provides a comprehensive framework for international cooperation on migration. Unlike the 1951 Refugee Convention, it covers all types of international migrants, not just refugees.[64] The GCM has helped countries around the world by encouraging cooperation on migration management. Some examples include improving cooperation between countries to combat human trafficking and migrant smuggling, supporting the protection of migrant workers and vulnerable migrants, encouraging countries to improve border management while respecting human rights, promoting better collection and sharing of migration data to inform policymaking, and supporting international cooperation through organizations such as the International Organization for Migration. The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration is still in effect and remains an important international framework. It was adopted in December 2018 at the Intergovernmental Conference to Adopt the Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration in Marrakesh and endorsed later in 2018 by the United Nations General Assembly.[65] The GCM is not legally binding; however, it

[62] EUAA. '2.1 The Common European Asylum System and Current Issues'. *European Union Agency for Asylum*, 2020, https://www.euaa.europa.eu/asylum-report-2020/21-common-european-asylum-system-and-current-issues.

[63] *#Ceas*. (n.d.). Retrieved 17 October 2026, from https://www.euaa.europa.eu/sites/default/files/2024-06/2024_CEAS_timeline-v8.pdf

[64] International Organization for Migration. (2019, January 25). *Global compact for migration*. International Organization for Migration. https://www.iom.int/global-compact-migration

[65] General, UN. (2019, January 11). *Global compact for safe, orderly and regular migration :: Resolution /: Adopted by the General Assembly*. UN,. United Nations Digital Library System. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/1660537?ln=en&v=pdf

provides guidance for countries to cooperate on migration issues, protect migrants' rights, and promote safe, orderly, and regular migration.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

Germany's integration courses

Germany's Integration Courses were expanded following a large increase in refugee arrivals, particularly during the 2015 refugee crisis, with the purpose of helping newcomers participate independently in German society.[66] The courses combine German-language education with civic instruction covering German laws, political institutions, democratic values, and everyday life. Their main aim is therefore not only to teach refugees the language, but also to provide them with the knowledge needed to navigate through the new society.[67] Vocational training and employment programs complemented this approach by helping refugees develop skills and access the labour market. Overall, this policy has been moderately effective, as participation in integration courses has helped many refugees improve their German language skills and understand German institutions; however, its effectiveness has been limited by factors such as differences in refugees' educational backgrounds and the varying quality and availability of programmes across regions. Furthermore, focusing heavily on learning German and adapting to German social norms can risk placing the responsibility for integration primarily on refugees rather than encouraging adaptation within the host society as well. The programme could therefore be improved by providing more personalised language and vocational training, accelerating the recognition of foreign qualifications, and strengthening cooperation between employers and integration providers.

Uganda's Self-Reliance Model

Uganda's self-reliance model aims to move away from traditional refugee camps by allowing displaced people to become economically and socially active members of their host society.[68] The policy allows refugees to work legally, move relatively freely, and access public services such as education and healthcare, reducing their dependence on humanitarian aid. Uganda has also been providing refugees with access to land for agriculture, an act intended to support their self-sufficiency

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[66] Kanas, A., & Kosyakova, Y. (2022). Greater local supply of language courses improves refugees' labor market integration. *European Societies*, *25*(1), 1–36. https://doi.org/10.1080/14616696.2022.2096915

[67] *The content and stages of the procedure*. (n.d.). BAMF - Bundesamt Für Migration Und Flüchtlinge. Retrieved October 15, 2026, from https://www.bamf.de/EN/Themen/Integration/ZugewanderteTeilnehmende/Integrationskurse/InhaltAblauf/inhaltablauf-node.html

[68] *Will Uganda's 'open-door' refugee policy hold? Aid cuts and rising anti-immigration sentiments - Egmont Institute*. (2025). Egmontinstitute.Be. https://egmontinstitute.be/will-ugandas-open-door-refugee-policy-hold-aid-cuts-and-rising-anti-immigration-sentiments/

while also allowing them to contribute to local economies through farming and trade. This approach has been highly effective in promoting refugees' economic independence and reducing the social isolation associated with long-term camp confinement. However, the current model faces significant limitations, particularly because Uganda has limited resources and hosts a large refugee population.[69] Access to land, employment, and education can vary considerably between communities, meaning that legal rights do not always translate into equal opportunities in practice. Overall, Uganda demonstrates that integration can be encouraged through self-reliance rather than isolation, but its success depends heavily on sufficient resources, strong relations with host communities, and measures that protect cultural identity alongside economic independence.

Turkey's education and labour market reforms

Turkey's education and labour market reforms aim to help the country's large Syrian refugee population become economically independent and participate more in Turkish society.[70] Providing refugees with access to public education is particularly important for preventing the emergence of a permanently marginalised generation of children who may otherwise lack the qualifications needed for future employment. Turkish language courses similarly aim to reduce communication barriers and enable refugees to interact more effectively with schools, workplaces, and local communities. Furthermore, work permits and vocational training are intended to reduce refugees' dependence on informal employment and humanitarian assistance while allowing them to contribute to the Turkish economy. These measures have been partially effective, as they have expanded refugees' access to education and created additional pathways towards employment and social participation. However, their impact has been limited by barriers such as language difficulties, complicated administrative procedures, discrimination, and the prevalence of informal employment among Syrian refugees.[71] Moreover, access to education has also been affected by factors such as poverty, mobility, and difficulties faced by refugee children when entering the Turkish school system.

Possible Solutions

Support mechanisms

Effective support mechanisms are essential for helping refugees who experience discrimination rebuild their confidence and participate fully in society. Many refugees are reluctant to report

[69] Berke, T., & Larsen, L. (2022). Using land to promote refugee self-reliance in Uganda. *Land*, *11*(3), 410. https://doi.org/10.3390/land11030410

[70] Europa. (n.d.-d). https://www.europarl.europa.eu/RegData/etudes/STUD/2016/595328/IPOL_STU(2016)595328_EN.pdf

[71] Tasli-Karabulut, V., & Sancak, M. (2024). Vocational education and training: A pathway for refugees' integration in the labour market? Lessons from Syrian refugees in Tarsus, Turkey. *Industrial Relations Journal*, *55*(6), 401–424. https://doi.org/10.1111/irj.12442

incidents[72] due to language barriers, fear of retaliation, and lack of knowledge about their rights; therefore, governments and community organisations could provide accessible legal assistance, counselling services, and multilingual helplines to ensure that victims receive the support they need. In addition, dedicated support centres can offer guidance on reporting discrimination and accessing social services. Training frontline professionals, such as police officers, teachers, and healthcare workers, to respond sensitively to discrimination cases can further improve the quality of assistance available.

Language and communication programs

One of the most effective ways to address the cultural assimilation challenges faced by marginalized refugee communities is through comprehensive language and communication programs. Language is often the primary barrier preventing refugees from fully participating in their host society.[73] Governments and community organisations can provide free language classes tailored to different age groups and educational backgrounds. These programs should go beyond basic language instruction and include practical communication skills needed for employment, education, healthcare, and everyday interactions. Additionally, interpretation or translation services could be added in public institutions to ensure that refugees can access essential services without misunderstanding or discrimination. By improving communication skills, refugees gain confidence, become more independent, and are better able to engage with the broader community while maintaining connections to their native languages.

Community-based cultural exchange programs

Rather than expecting refugees to abandon their cultural identities, cultural exchange programs encourage mutual understanding and respect between refugees and residents. Cultural festivals, art exhibitions, food fairs, and sports activities provide opportunities for people from different backgrounds to interact in positive and meaningful ways. Exchanges such as these help challenge stereotypes, reduce prejudice, and promote social cohesion; by celebrating cultural diversity, communities can create an atmosphere where refugees feel welcomed while local populations gain a deeper appreciation for different traditions and perspectives.

Education

Schools are often the first place where refugee children encounter the culture and values of the host society; therefore, educational institutions could adopt inclusive curricula that represent diverse cultures and histories, including those of refugee populations. Teachers could receive training on

[72] Navarro, C. (2022). *Hate crime reporting barriers: Why are victims reluctant to report?* Tackling Hate. https://tacklinghate.org/trainingmodule/hate-crime-reporting-barriers-why-victims-of-hate-related-incidents-are-reluctant-to-report2/

[73] WHO. (2025, May 6). *Refugee and migrant mental health*. Who.Int; World Health Organization: WHO. https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/refugee-and-migrant-mental-health

cultural sensitivity and trauma-informed practices to better support students who may have experienced displacement, conflict, or loss, and schools can also establish mentorship programs and peer-support initiatives that help refugee students adapt socially and academically. Such measures create an environment where refugee children feel valued and accepted, reducing the risk of exclusion and helping them build meaningful relationships with their peers.

Economic integration

Refugees frequently face difficulties finding employment due to language barriers, non-recognition of qualifications, or discrimination. Governments can implement policies that simplify the recognition of foreign credentials and provide vocational training programs that match local labor market needs. Employers can be encouraged to hire refugees through diversity initiatives, awareness campaigns, and incentives. Stable employment not only provides financial security but also enables refugees to interact with members of the host society, learn cultural norms, and contribute positively to the economy.

Anti-discrimination policies

Refugees may face unequal treatment in employment, housing, education, healthcare, and access to public services, making strong legal protections essential. Governments can enact and enforce comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation that clearly prohibits discrimination based on nationality, ethnicity, religion, or refugee status. In addition, independent bodies should be responsible for monitoring compliance, investigating complaints, and imposing appropriate penalties on individuals or organisations that violate these laws. Regular reviews of existing legislation can also ensure that legal protections remain effective and address emerging forms of discrimination.

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